



IIMFiELD
Indian Institute of Management Visakhapatnam
A holistic entrepreneurial ecosystem

BREAKING BOUNDARIES



**WOMEN STARTUP
PROGRAM COHORT *2*
2020-2022**





The IIMV Foundation for Incubation Entrepreneurial Learning and Development (IIMV FIELD) is the Incubation and Startup Hub of IIM Visakhapatnam. It is a Section 8 company which aims to promote, develop, and nurture the culture of entrepreneurship and innovation. The incubator has been making an impact in the ecosystem since 2018, when it started entrepreneurship activities with the Women Startup Program (WSP) in partnership with the N.S. Raghavan Centre for Entrepreneurial Learning (NSRCEL) of IIM Bangalore.

Over the years, IIMV FIELD has received recognition from various governmental bodies; including the Ministry for Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY - TIDE2.0 Program) and the Department of Science & Technology (DST - NIDHI Accelerator Program). The incubator has also received CSR funding from MTAR Technologies Ltd. for supporting social ventures & from NBCC India Ltd. for supporting women led ventures. Currently, IIMV FIELD has incubated 116 startups in 7 flagship programs, out of which 52 have graduated and 93 are founded by women.

As a management-based incubator, IIMV FIELD is sector agnostic and can

support entrepreneurs across all sectors. However, in the direction of becoming a world-class incubation center, IIMV FIELD plans to strategically scale up its 7 existing programs and add new programs to its portfolio of services. The incubator plans to support women, student, and social entrepreneurs. Along with EduTech, FinTech, export-oriented, and other emerging tech-based ventures. It will deliver pre-incubation, incubation, acceleration, and seed support programs.

Moreover, IIMV FIELD plans to explore the strengths of the local region; i.e logistics, marine, health & wellness, and tourism sectors specifically. The incubator plans to do entrepreneurship development programs to build competencies in faculties of K-12 schools, engineering/science colleges in AP & TS, and managers of E-Cells, E-Labs in the region.

Overall, IIMV FIELD is committed to creating a conducive environment for fostering and supporting entrepreneurship and innovation, and with its strategic plans. Being well on its way to becoming a world-class incubation center.



Prasad Dahapute

Member - BoG (IIMV) & Chairman - BoD (IIMV FIELD)

Entrepreneurship is the most important driver of our economy through innovation and employment generation. We need to build the environment where entrepreneurs can learn and develop innovative business models that create employment. To accelerate the entrepreneurship, we, at Indian Institute of Management, Visakhapatnam, set up a Section 8 company; IIMV FIELD.

There are multiple surveys in India that talk about the falling share of working women within the pool of the working age population. The other side, that these surveys don't talk about, is different. Indian women are more entrepreneurial than Indian men. So most of them are joining the entrepreneurship bandwagon in their own way. To accelerate this spirit of self-employment among Indian women, we launched the Women Startup Program (WSP) and supported 25 women led ventures in the first cohort 2018-19.

Inspired by the success and impact of the initiative, we launched the second cohort of this program, and supported 20 women led ventures in 2020-22. I had the privilege of interacting with some of the startup founders, such as Harshita Lalchand, Aruna Gali, and Latha Pudi in person at our incubation centre. I would like to highlight some of the themes in our WSP that are going to dominate the economic growth in near future. Agritech and sustainable consumption are going to be the themes dominating the growth on account of climate change. Fortunately, we have Kisanlinks India and Indian Shroom Company in these sectors. I wish them all the best.

Our Director (Operations), Prof. Shameem Jawed, has done a phenomenal job in getting the women entrepreneurs to apply for the program and then a tough job of selecting the best among them under the leadership of our Managing Director, Prof. M. Chandrasekhar. Our Director (Finance), Prof. Deepika Gupta, and the entire team at the Foundation, have helped us in meeting the compliance requirements of the funding agencies as well as statutory agencies.

IIMV-FIELD is committed to meet the goal of AtmaNirbhar Bharat through accelerating the empowerment of women entrepreneurship and would be launching similar programs in near future again. I wish all the best to all of our women entrepreneurs.



Prof. M Chandrasekhar

Director (IIMV) & Managing Director (IIMV FIELD)

The IIMV Foundation for Incubation, Entrepreneurial Learning, and Development (IIMV FIELD) is the vibrant startup and innovation hub of Indian Institute of Management Visakhapatnam; an institution of national importance.

Our vision at IIMV is to champion and excel in educating and nurturing entrepreneurial leaders in creating innovative solutions for business, government, and society. IIMV FIELD is a result of such thought leadership.

We are thus committed to educating and supporting leaders who can contribute as entrepreneurs, and stewards, of existing and emerging enterprises.

Accordingly, in our own modest way, we are giving flight to the dreams of the (aspiring) women-entrepreneurs by building their capacities and providing them with funding for proof-of-concept and proto-typing, access to the incubation facilities and knowledge resources, mentoring and hand-holding support, networking with industry and investors, and opportunities to showcase their technologies and products on a variety of promotional platforms. Leveraging our support systems and investing their creative energies, our entrepreneurs are making a positive difference in society. They deserve fullsome praise. We are proud of being a part of their success.

As a recognition for our rapidly expanding good work at the Foundation, we have been receiving funding from the Central Government as well as public sector and private (corporate) sector enterprises. These sources of valuable support help us reinforce our commitment to education, entrepreneurship, and empowerment.

I place on record my gratitude to the leadership at the Centre, State and Andhra University, and our Board ably led by Chairman Shri Prasad Dahapute, for their contribution to the growth and good functioning, and to all the benefactors and stakeholders, for their continued patronage and partnership in the Foundation's progress and success.

I compliment the Director (Operations); Prof. M S Jawed, Director (Finance); Prof. Deepika Gupta, and the entire team at the Foundation, who, with passion and enthusiasm, have been the prime catalysts in our endeavours.

The Foundation stands committed to being an enabler and facilitator of the startup ecosystem and Atmanirbhar Mission of New India, advancing and accelerating the success of technology-based, women-led, and for-women ventures.

**Prof. Deepika Gupta***Director (Finance), IIMV FIELD*

It is a delight and pleasure to write the foreword for the Coffee Book Table 2023 for IIMV FIELD. It has been an honour and privilege to be nominated by Board of Governors of Indian Institute of Management Visakhapatnam (IIMV) as First Director of the Company. IIMV FIELD was incorporated on July 17, 2020, and has been taking small steps to make a mark for itself for 'a holistic entrepreneurial ecosystem'. It is in its third year of incorporation, but

IIMV FIELD has been working on entrepreneurial growth and development since 2018 through the Women Startup Programs under its mentor; IIM Bangalore.

In the past two years, IIMV FIELD has seen its balance sheet grow to Rupees one crore and I am hopeful that it continues to be stronger and brighter. The incubator has been instrumental in successfully achieving grants from Government of India through programs like TIDE 2.0, from Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MietY), and Nidhi Accelerator, from Department of Science and Technology (DST). IIMV FIELD has been able to successfully pitch for CSR grants from prestigious organizations such as MTAR Technologies Pvt Ltd and NBCC India Ltd.

IIMV FIELD has been through its journey of key achievements, challenges, and various opportunities. I am confident that the incubator shall be having its positive bottom line as the Company gears up for more internal revenue generation through various capacity building programs, workshops, knowledge series, and others. IIMV FIELD is also careful about its cost-saving measures and is continuously seeking new avenues in terms of grants and funds.

As Director (Finance), I feel proud of achieving certain significant milestones and we continue to remain committed to improving our financial performances to meet the vision, mission, and goals of the Company. I would like to thank our Chairman Shri Prasad Dahapute ji, the Directors, and employees for their hard work and dedication, as well as our partners, the government bodies, and respective incubatees for their continued support. I am also confident of meeting our focus on growth and continue to drive positive financial results for the Company.



Prof. M Shameem Jawed

Program Director - WSP & Director (Operations), IIMV FIELD

As the Program Director of the Women Startup Program (WSP) – 2021-22 cohort, I am thrilled to introduce this coffee table book that showcases the remarkable journey of women entrepreneurs who participated in the program.

The Women Startup Program is an exceptional initiative that aims to provide women entrepreneurs with the necessary resources, knowledge, and financial support to help them launch and grow their ventures. The program focuses on enhancing the entrepreneurial and managerial skills of women leading early and ideation stage ventures, making learning accessible, affordable, and unbounded; especially for women living in Tier-2 and Tier-3 cities.

I would like to take this opportunity to extend my heartfelt gratitude to the team at IIMV FIELD for their exceptional support throughout the incubation phase; especially Mr. Harsha Vikas Dhanalakota, who played a pivotal role in liaising with the startups and providing valuable guidance to the entrepreneurs. I would also like to thank the leadership team of IIMV FIELD, Shri Prasad Dahapute (Chairman), Prof. M Chandrasekhar (MD), and Prof. Deepika Gupta (Director - Finance), for their continued and unconditional support to this program.

I would like to express my deep appreciation to all the mentors who mentored and supported the startups at various stages of their journey, providing valuable inputs and guidance. Their contributions were essential to the success of the program.

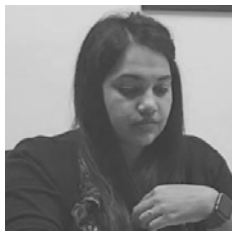
We would not have been able to accomplish this without the support of our program partners, NSRCEL - IIM Bangalore, and sponsors, Kotak Mahindra Bank. We are grateful for their unwavering commitment to this program and their efforts to support women entrepreneurs.

Finally, I would like to congratulate the startups featured in this book for their hard work and dedication in bringing their ideas to fruit. I hope that their success stories will inspire other women entrepreneurs to pursue their dreams and create a better future for themselves and their communities.

ENTREPRENEURS



Shruti Ajmera Reddy
Founder
Hapup



Priyanka Tayi
Founder
Kula Studio



Neha M Shah
Founder
People of Prints



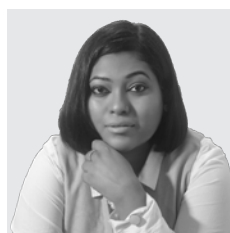
Apeksha Kalari
Founder
Projoy Probiotics



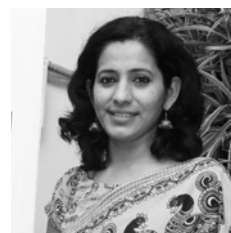
Aruna Gali
Founder
School Radio



Latha Pudi
Founder
Cocoa Buzzz



Sushmita Basak
Founder
Sugar Shell



Harshita Lalchand
Founder
All is Well



Priyanka Achhpeliya
Founder
Aasmaan



Ankitha Chiluka
Founder
Indian Shroom Company



Supriya Kulkarni
Founder
Vivid Puzzles



Dr. Aparna Ayyagari
Founder
Vidh-Ya



Aayushi Jauhari
Founder
Kayantar Foundation



Alisha Garnaik
Founder
The Period Pratha



Dissy George
Founder
Back to Nature



Pooja Agarwal
Founder
Flow Experiences



Chabi Agarwal
Founder
Learning Buffet



Bhavana Kondeti
Founder
TraditionOnWay



Sireesha M
Founder
KisanLinks India



Srividya Pinapala
Founder
Midore



The Second Cohort of Women Startup Program (WSP) at IIMV FIELD supported 20 women entrepreneurs, from Andhra Pradesh & Telangana State, in transforming their ideas into business ventures through incubation support. The program is initiated by NSRCEL of IIM Bangalore and is funded through CSR grants of Kotak Mahindra Bank.

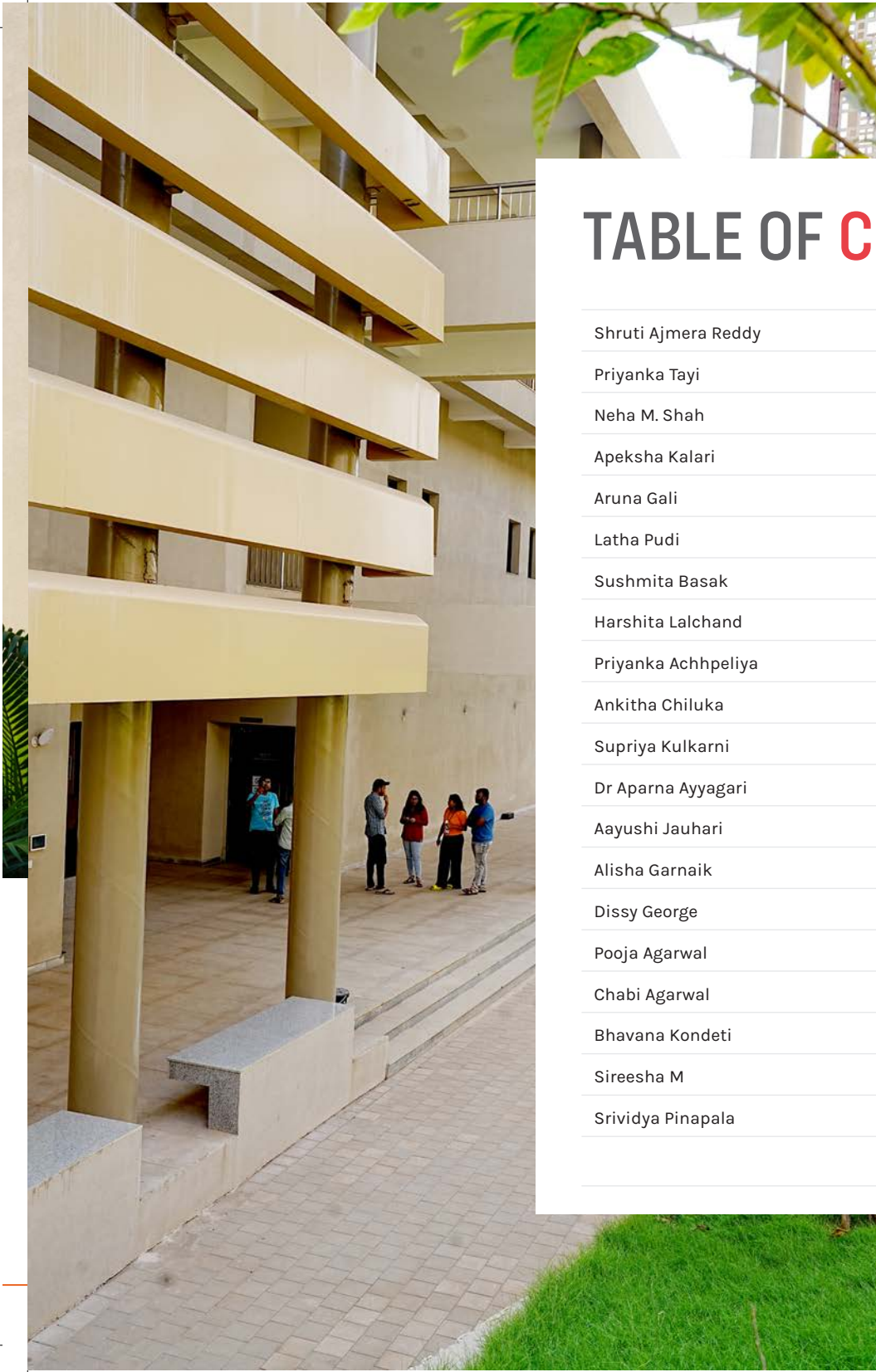


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Shruti Ajmera Reddy

Hapup

Nutritional cereal mixes for toddlers is the premise on which Hapup was conceived and the fact that these mixes are appetizing, yet free from chemical additives and preservatives, contributed to its success.

In this day and age of instant foods, and busy moms and dads, cooking healthy meals for a toddler from scratch is challenging. And simplifying that process is an innovative start-up; Hapup. This enterprise provides a healthy, nutritious, and balanced diet for young growing children. The start-up's focus is on using naturally processed regional ingredients, essential for a child's growth and development, in the right blend. Hapup nutri-mixes are easy to cook and serve.

The brains behind the initiative, Shruti Ajmera Reddy, came up with the idea when she found it tough to incorporate healthy and yet easy-to-use ingredients in her son's meals. "Back in the day, I realised that there weren't enough options for healthy baby foods in the market. Then, I decided to make my own and began a year-long endeavour working with the food scientists at the ICMR - National Institute of Nutrition. I was also fortunate to get valuable inputs from my father-in-law, Dr P Sudarshan Reddy, a leading paediatrician," she says.

Hapup's mixes contain healthy ingredients like ragi, jowar, bajra, foxtail millet, horse gram, kidney beans, green gram, almond, peanuts, and red rice among others. Most of these grains have been sourced by farming collectives, like the Timbaktu Collective, which ensures that they are of good quality. The ready-to-cook mixes are completely natural and contain the goodness of about 16 plus ingredients. Cooking these mixes is so simple that even a harried parent or grandparent can do it.

Talking about the startup's journey, Shruti says, "The best part about my job is, I'm able to touch so many lives and provide nourishment to thousands of little ones just like mine. Since we started operations, Hapup has been able to reach about 45+ cities and 1000+ villages across India. Our products have also been approved by paediatricians and hospitals; like the Nice Hospital

Hapup™

NATURALLY MADE ♥ NATURALLY LOVED

and Krishna Children's Hospital amongst others.”

Shruti Ajmera Reddy joined IIMV FIELD during the pandemic. She reveals that it was a rewarding experience as she had mentors, from both IIMV FIELD and NSRCEL, offering their guidance. Furthermore, she benefitted from the opportunity of interacting with almost 200 resilient women batchmates having similar goals. Classroom sessions and practical applications apart, the program included regular pitches every two months that helped each participant refine themselves further. Fortified with inputs and ideas from the programme, Shruti and her team went back to basics. They focussed on product quality and standardising the manufacturing process. The Hapup founder claims that all these efforts had contributed towards scaling up the company with the right theme, right message, and the right product.





Priyanka Tayi

Kula Studio

Hyderabad-based fashion designer Priyanka Tayi, who was shocked by 'fashion waste', founded a company called Kula Studio. The startup provides sustainable refashioning and upcycling services for the clothes you own.

Priyanka Tayi is a fashion designer who has had the opportunity to work with some of the biggest names in the fashion industry. After having created, designed, and worked with fast fashion brands, the pandemic threw a million questions at her — especially ones about the growing pile of waste at landfills. During this period, she set out to offer solutions to this growing problem. That's when an idea bulb in her head shone bright. Priyanka decided to provide upcycled and re-fashioned services, for peoples' second hand clothes, through a digitally responsive website.

Her startup idea was further nurtured when she enrolled for the Women Startup Program (WSP) by IIM Visakhapatnam. Priyanka reveals that the program breathed life into her idea and made Kula Studio what it is today. She found that the program gave clarity on how she could embark on her venture and progress. Her mentors and WSP cohort encouraged her to focus on validating her idea and work on its marketability.

In the process of refashioning clothes, Kula Studio also practice zero wastage. Explaining how, Priyanka says that they source dead-stock of consciously produced fabrics and vegan leather, thereby benefitting the clusters and ethical brands of the country. They honour the process and believe in using every last scrap of responsibly produced textiles. Some include unsold inventory of handloom, and organic, naturally dyed fabrics as well as export stock excess that's just sitting with the weaver which is otherwise discarded.

Taking us through how she put the startup together, Priyanka says that a lot of research went into creating Kula Studio. Their team spoke to over 600 men and women, who are regular shoppers, who told them about the kind of fabrics and styles they'd like most. Priya noticed that denim and sarees were the most popular styles while cotton and silk were the most common

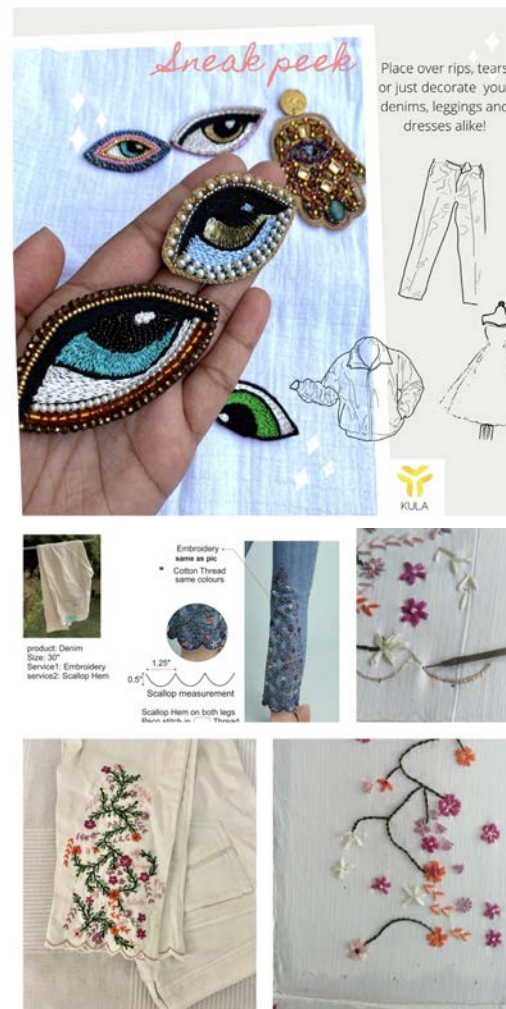


fabrics. Through this, they created set templates allowing people to play around with these combinations. Kula Studio enables consumers to choose a style for something they already own or pick something from their fabrics.

One of the most laudable features of the brand has to be Kula Studio's *avatar* guide. They curated a new size guide after having spoken to many people who shared how they feel like they don't fit into the standard sizes of Small, Medium, Large, etc. She adds that it's also a one-time investment where you enter your details and the website curates your avatar.

Now, they are a team of nine members with a strong presence and have received orders from over 55 pin codes across India. Kula Studio offers pan-India free pick up within 24 hours of placing an order and delivers products repurposed garments, bags, buntings, etc., within 4-5 working days.

On what's next, Priyanka says that with the diaspora being extremely supportive, they hope to grow beyond the country, and work on their website and designs to get more tech-savvy in the future.





Neha M Shah

People of Prints

Having seen a sporadic growth in technology and resurgence of photo prints, Neha M Shah started People of Prints (PoP). Her venture is all about saving memories in a digital world; one print at a time.

As a lover of memories and all things personalized, Neha Shah founded People of Prints; a company that specializes in creating unique, fun, and personalized gifts, as well as offering photo printing solutions for both individuals and businesses.

Through her company, Neha aims to provide individuals and companies with the opportunity to preserve their memories in a tangible and meaningful way. PoP provides an array of technologically advanced print services like Polaroid style prints, photo frames, large prints, photo strips, and add-ons such as photo magnets and magnetic photo ropes.

One of People of Prints' most unique products is MAGNETO, a damage-free wall hanging solution that allows customers to display their favorite memories without the hassle of nails or hooks. MAGNETO is a popular choice among customers and has been featured in several publications. People of Prints also offers live photo printing technology through its 'PoP Machine'. A first of its kind, their 'PoP Machine' is a portable, easy-to-use device that allows customers to print their photos on the spot via any social media channel.

This technology is particularly useful at weddings, parties, and corporate events where guests can take home physical prints of their favorite moments. For businesses and media companies, People of Prints offers APIs that allow them to easily integrate live photo printing technology into their events and services.

PoP's growing online presence constantly motivates Neha, and her team, to push boundaries and create innovative products. Adding a feather to the cap, Neha's PoP got shortlisted for Women Startup Program (WSP) 3.0 by IIM Visakhapatnam. Being someone who never actively approached people to seek help, Neha shares that this programme opened up new avenues for her venture.



With regards to just the photo booth experience, with the printer, People of Prints has now teamed up with partners in — Bengaluru, Mumbai, Chennai, and other cities.

In a world where everything is moving towards digital, People of Prints recognizes the importance of preserving memories in a tangible form. As PoP brings convenience to people's lives, Neha is glad that it's adding a bit of colour too.





Apeksha Kalari

Projoy Probiotics

How to think like an entrepreneur? That's what Apeksha Kalari learnt from this program and helped her put Projoy Probiotics successfully in the market.

At times, having healthy food may not be sufficient for maintaining our physical well being. Ensuring that the food is beneficially digested and that all the good nutrition is assimilated in the body is essential; and that is where probiotics play a key role. Apeksha Kalari, and her husband Satish, learnt first-hand the importance and effectiveness of probiotics during their stay in the United States. Both were into research, working at the University of Chicago.

It was there that they came across probiotics, which are good friendly bacteria created by nature. Long hours, hectic schedules, and erratic eating habits impacted their health. Satish began to suffer from acidity and Apeksha's LDL levels were high. Changing their food habits didn't give them the desired results. After some research, they found that adding probiotics into their diet made all the difference. Their personal health journey led them both to incorporate probiotics to combat acidity and high cholesterol, resulting in the birth of Projoy Probiotics. Apeksha acquired valuable knowledge in entrepreneurship from the IIMV FIELD and NSRCEL programs.

Their experience with probiotics, and growing demand for healthy and quality products amongst Indians, motivated them to popularise and make probiotics more easily accessible.

Apeksha Kalari, being a Master's graduate in Microbiology and Biotechnology, is fascinated by nature. She learnt that probiotics are the beneficial bacteria naturally found in the gut which aid digestion and boost immunity. However, factors like stress, lack of sleep, pollution, and unhealthy eating habits can disrupt the gut's balance, allowing harmful bacteria to thrive. The solution is to incorporate probiotics into a healthy lifestyle with nutritious food.

Projoy Probiotics, learning from personal experience and scientific research, came up with multi-strain probiotic powders and formulations



that are easy to incorporate in one's daily diet. But most significantly, their probiotic products are without sugar, making them one of the healthiest options in the market today; especially for diabetics and pregnant women.

The company combines multiple strains of beneficial bacteria to develop a cutting-edge probiotic food supplement powder, with a strong emphasis on the significance of gut health in overall well-being. Their products are specifically designed to repair, restore, and improve gut health, and the company aims to showcase the safety, effectiveness, and potential health benefits of their products to the general public.

Projoy Probiotic's formulation has undergone extensive research and testing to ensure optimal stability, potency, and bioavailability of the probiotic strains. The company offers a range of products designed for digestive wellness, immune wellness, metabolic wellness, women's wellness, and kids' wellness; each with several unique products that address specific health concerns and provide targeted benefits. Projoy Probiotic aims to reach individuals looking for a natural way to enhance their gut health and improve their overall well-being.





Aruna Gali

School Radio

Presenting School Radio, a pioneering platform where children are encouraged to create and present their own programmes.

Ever wondered how varied is the educational approach amongst government and private schools? Ask Aruna Katragadda Gali. She studied in different kinds of schools as she was educated in different parts of Andhra Pradesh, right up till her Post-Graduation. Be it her stimulating background or her inherent curious nature, Aruna strongly believes in learning and exploring new aspects and cultures. Speaking her mind on the reason why she started School Radio, she says, “I enjoy working with children and youth. It is their innocence and inquisitiveness that fascinates me. And it is that very inquisitiveness that motivated me to do something for them.”

Having worked in the media and the social development sector, Aruna realised that youth, in general, have a lot of issues with communication, creativity, and critical thinking. Usually, children are conditioned and pressurised to study in a particular stream. Consequently, inherent traits, like ingenuity and curiosity, are crushed when the children are forced by parents, family, and society. An attempt to reignite those inherent traits is what this start-up is all about.

Working with Udaya Kumar, her husband and business partner, Aruna reveals, “School Radio is a social initiative that focusses on nurturing young change-makers in society. As an ideation lab, for children and youth between the ages of five to nineteen, we encourage them to create their own content. Our programme is crafted to help the youngsters master the essential skill sets including communication, creativity, collaboration, critical thinking, problem solving abilities, time management, employability skills, life skills, and green skills, to promote future endeavours.”

Aruna joined the program during the COVID-19 first wave when IIMV FIELD and NSRCEL had gone completely online. She found it convenient to attend the online sessions without taking a break from refining her start-up. Aruna shares that the programme has given her a lot of insights on how to focus on the venture as well as streamline and standardise the process. She is

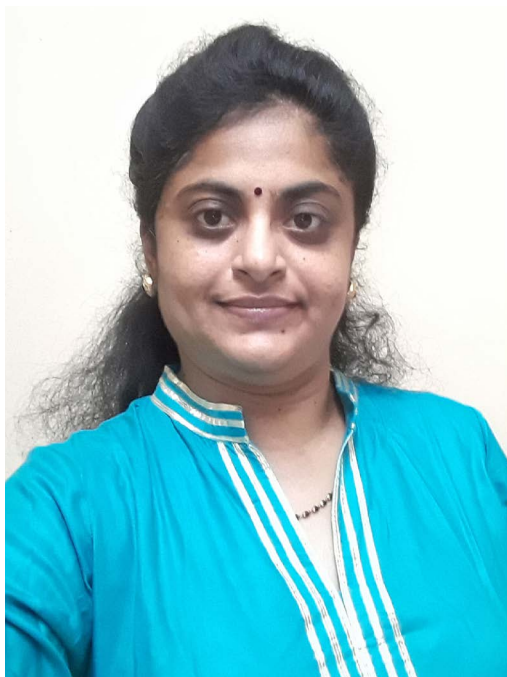


thankful to all the mentors and professors in the programme who helped her prioritise on the business aspect of her venture, but still maintain it as a social impact endeavour.

School Radio has already reached out to 50,000 households. Parents, community, and children have participated in creating content such as sustainable development goals. Academicians, researchers, scientists, and professionals, from different walks of life, have also shared their stories on this platform. They have also given tips on choosing varied careers. Thanks to this initiative, children are now exposed to newly emerging and creative careers rather than just engineering and medicine.

School Radio has given voice to 7,000 children and youth in 12 languages. It has also produced 15 publications in English, Sanskrit, & Telugu. The venture has now expanded to Sikkim and Udupi, Karnataka. In Sikkim, a workshop was held for 50 students and 10 academicians. In Udupi, an offline studio will soon be established to serve educational institutions on the West Coast of India.





Latha Pudi

Cocoa Buzzz

Latha Pudi's startup, Cocoa Buzzz, empowers cocoa farmers from, and around, Andhra Pradesh with its unique line of cocoa-based products.

A universal favorite, chocolates are a treat that almost everyone enjoys. And everyone knows that it's the revered cocoa bean that makes chocolates so delectable. But just how many are aware that the exalted cocoa bean is also grown in India, in the neighbouring areas of Visakhapatnam? Latha Pudi was unaware of this statistic too. In fact, until she visited her husband's farm a few hours' drive out of Visakhapatnam, she had never seen a cocoa plant. Her first encounter with the fabled cocoa tree left her intrigued and fascinated. And taking that fascination forward, she launched her own start-up, Cocoa Buzzz.

After completing her Masters in Business Administration from Andhra University, Latha worked for ten years in the banking and financial sector. Her curiosity regarding the bean took her onto a totally different path. When she saw the tree, she spoke to the local farmer about the cocoa bean and its growing conditions. Back home, she went online and delved further into the nitty-gritty details regarding the cultivation, processing, and marketing of the cocoa bean. Realizing that farmers were not getting paid enough for the effort they put into cultivating the cocoa bean, she decided to try and bridge the gap by means of Cocoa Value addition. Collaborating with the Indian Council of Agricultural Research (ICAR), and Central Plantation Research Institute, she learnt how to upcycle the raw cocoa bean into cocoa nibs, cocoa powder, and cocoa butter. Using the equipment from these institutes, she started processing and selling small batches of the products to B2B sellers, a few chocolatiers, and confectioneries. In her deep dive online exploring the world of cocoa, Latha connected with cocoa experts from India, Indonesia, Brazil, Germany, and USA.

She worked with a chocolatier in Mumbai who helped her in product development using the cocoa bean she grew. Her first ready-to-eat product,



the cocoa vegan spread, catered to all age groups and was very successful. Her next target was to learn more about recycling the Cocoa Agri residue.

Being a solopreneur company Latha worked with some interns and freelancers helping her on a need basis as cocoa is a seasonal crop. While her inspiration was the cocoa plant that she came across, helping her bring her idea to fruition were the mentors in the NSRCEL and IIMV FIELD programs that she attended. Latha reveals that it was the training aspect of the program, and the opportunity to interact with diverse peers across India, that keeps her excited and is an everyday learning for her.

Her biggest takeaways from the program were being keen to move forward, learning to keep calm while in chaos, and how to negotiate to get a better deal. Latha is grateful for the strong support and opportunities she received from the mentors and well-wishers and is continuing her journey with more confidence.





Sushmita Basak

Sugar Shell

Sushmita Basak, founder of Sugar Shell, is on a mission to help cancer survivors reclaim their femininity with specially designed intimate apparel and breast prosthetics.

For Sushmita Basak, although her education and career took interesting twists and turns, she eventually ended up following her true calling; Design Thinking. She studied Biomedical Engineering (Mumbai University), did a MBA in Finance [National Institute of Technical Teachers' Training and Research (NITTTR) , Bhopal], and Post-Graduate Diploma in Management (Securities Markets) [National Institute of Securities Markets (NISM)], and worked in a corporate job dealing with stocks and U.S. bonds (HDFC Securities, S&P Global & IHS Markit). Sushmita then chucked it all to do what she always wanted to do. She chose to indulge in her creativity.

From finance to fashion, Sushmita pursued her passion for sustainability by enrolling in a master's program, in garment design and operations, at NIFT. She stayed updated through design blogs and forums, while also engaging in discussions on social, economic, and women-centric issues. Her goal is to establish a women-oriented, and sustainability-focused, business. The idea for her start-up emerged from her award-winning graduation project that she did in her second year – designing undergarments and breast prosthetics for breast cancer patients. Her biomedical background and interest in ergonomics helped in making the product a success. Realising the advantages and potentiality of the product, Sushmita decided to explore its commercial viability.

Accordingly, she applied to IIM Bangalore, NSRCEL Women Startup Program, and with that came her association with IIMV FIELD. She entered the program with a vague but promising business idea. Thanks to the network and mentorship that came with the program, she emerged with a polished and decisive business plan. In this context she also reveals that for a solo entrepreneur it can be lonely, and at times frustrating, while navigating the ins and outs of a business venture. Which is why she says that motivation and a positive thought process is important. Which is where NSRCEL and IIMV FIELD made a difference.



Not only did the participants learn from the program, they also regularly interacted with one another and motivated each other. That kept the overall attitude amongst the budding entrepreneurs positive and elevated.

Sugar Shell Brands is a lingerie brand that not only celebrates breast health but also designs post-surgery undergarments related to addressing various women's health issues. They are currently focused on creating safe, ergonomically designed, and good quality inner-wear and breast prosthetics for chemo patients and breast cancer survivors. Sugar Shell is a one stop solution targeting each phase the cancer survivors undergo in their lifetime i.e from chemotherapy to surgery to the recovery phase. The idea is to provide a practical and usable range of products for whichever stage of the treatment the person is undergoing.

In a nutshell, Sugar Shell is an enterprise with a social cause giving breast cancer survivors a viable option to lead a more normal lifestyle. Adding a feather to its cap, Sugar Shell has recently raised 22 Lac from NDBI NID A (taken 6 Lac for now) and another social CSR grant from HDFC Bank for around 16.8 Lac.





Harshita Lalchand

All is Well

In a highly-competitive world wherein the day-to-day life turns stressful for some, Harshita Lalchand's mental wellness startup, 'All is Well' is in pursuit to make people accept the fact that it is okay, not to be okay!

Inspiration and motivation can come from the unlikeliest of places. For Harshita Lalchand, it was her daughter's innocuous remark that helped her overcome her internal misgivings and take a decisive step forward. Shedding light on the incident that shaped her career, Ms Lalchand said, "Continuing studies after fourteen years of marriage with two kids, was a challenge in itself. And when I joined coaching classes for the MBA entrance exam, I was dissuaded by an instructor in the coaching class."

Disillusioned, she returned home, only to swing back into mom-mode as her younger daughter, Naisha, needed her attention. Putting aside her own insecurities, she focussed on helping the young girl overcome her mathphobia and prepare for a math test the next day. She kept encouraging and boosting her panicky daughter's confidence while helping her understand the mathematical concepts. The result was as expected; the girl did pretty well in her test.

Adding further details about the fateful day, she said, "My daughter came home and thanked me. But here's the twist. She did not thank her mom for helping her study, rather she thanked me because I made her believe in herself. And that sentence got me thinking; if I could inspire my daughter to overcome her math phobia, why couldn't I motivate myself?"

Consequently, not only did she give the entrance exam and clear with a decent score, she went on to complete her MBA and even an MSc in Psychology. Looking back, she says, often obstacles are self-created and are all in the mind. Being a Behavioural and Mental Space Psychologist, and with her background in Psychology and NLP, she explains, "Each one of us have the ability to overcome challenges with the right determination and support system. Sometimes all it takes is a few words to instill confidence and help to nudge one onto the right path."

Harshita's venture, All is Well, is all about building confidence. It is primarily about emotional and mental wellbeing. The start-up, co-founded with



her elder daughter Tushika Lalchand, provides sessions which include well-being initiatives for corporate employees to help improve performance and enhance their mindfulness by dealing with stress, anxiety and adversity. They offer training programmes based on the needs of the client and one-to-one counselling services.

Speaking about her elder daughter, Harshita shares, “Tushika is my biggest support system and my best critic. She is a diploma holder in Mental Space Psychology in India and an NLP practitioner. Currently, she is researching how the services at All Is Well can be extended to students also, so that teen mental and emotional well-being could be assessed and addressed incorporating multiple interventions.”

In addition to being incubated at NSRCEL and IIMV FIELD, the start-up has also been part of IIM Calcutta Innovation Park (IIMCIP) of IIM-C. Harshita reveals that she just had an idea but no clue on how to get started or take it forward. And that’s where incubating with NSRCEL and IIMV FIELD helped.

People are hesitant to seek counselling or training for good mental health due to social taboo. However, Harshita is optimistic about raising awareness and is willing to take gradual steps forward.





Priyanka Achhpeeliya

Aasmaan

Priyanka Achhpeeliya is on her way to bridge the gap between Indian textiles and the youth through her startup Aasmaan.

With roots in craft and community, Priyanka's lineage in the apparel industry traces back to her family's suiting-shirting and readymade stores in Vijayawada. During her graduation in NIFT, she got an opportunity to interact with artisans from craft clusters in Andhra Pradesh. There she came across an artisan who was weaving a unique fabric. After interacting with him, Priyanka got to know that he was the only one in the entire village who knew that weaving technique. This made her wonder about the various crafts in the country which might be on the verge of extinction.

However, graduating amidst the lockdown brought with it a lot of confusion. Though the young fashion designer was getting job offers from Hyderabad, she decided to give her dream a shot. The research and sampling process took about a year and a half because of the lack of accessibility to resources and limited movement due to the COVID-19 pandemic.

She attended a lot of online workshops and webinars, hosted by industry experts, and learnt in detail about sustainable fashion. During this time, she got the opportunity to be incubated at IIMV FIELD alongside 19 women entrepreneurs from Andhra Pradesh and Telangana. Priyanka credits WSP for handholding women entrepreneurs. She admits that it was during this program, she got a stronghold of the finance, marketing, design thinking, pitching, storytelling, and legal requirements of a business. All these learnings gave her the confidence she needed to go ahead with the execution.

With her brother, Omesh Achhpeeliya, she founded Aasmaan - an artisanal casual wear brand for women with an aim to bridge the gap between heritage Indian textiles and the youth.

Priyanka went ahead and sourced fabric directly from the weavers for the initial inventory development. Aasmaan had a beta launch at a local



flea market in Visakhapatnam. Their target audience loved the quality, look, and feel of the products which pushed the team further to start creating more pieces.

Priyanka believes that every craft has some history attached to it and losing even one of them would mean losing a part of our culture and history. Spreading their wings, Aasmaan is now associated with more than 15 weaving clusters across India. More than 75 artisans are in collaboration with Aasmaan which is an applaudable feat in itself.

Aasmaan's product range consists of Tops, Shirts, Jackets, Dresses, Skirts, Trousers, Crochet Accessories, Fabric Belts etc. Their products are available for purchase on their website, Swiggy Minis, Etsy, and social media handles.





Ankitha Chiluka

Indian Shroom Company

With its cutting-edge technology, and socially responsible practices, Ankitha Chiluka's Indian Shroom Company is on its way to transform the mushroom industry.

During the COVID-19 pandemic, Ankitha stumbled upon mushrooms while working as a lead R&D engineer at an additive manufacturing start-up in Hyderabad. Being a mushroom enthusiast, Ankitha noticed that locally grown Milky and Oyster mushrooms were not readily available on supermarket shelves, despite their nutritional and health benefits. After conducting further research, and seeing the potential profitability, Ankitha left her corporate job to start a mushroom unit on a small scale that eventually grew into a successful business.

Despite making good revenue, Ankitha felt that her business lacked social impact. She believed that a startup should not only generate revenue but also have a significant positive impact on society. To achieve this, Ankitha and her team developed a sustainable, scalable, and socially responsible business model that empowers local farmers, marginalized communities, and self-help groups. They facilitate these groups with the necessary tools and resources to grow high-quality mushrooms, which not only provide a reliable source of income but also promote sustainable agriculture.

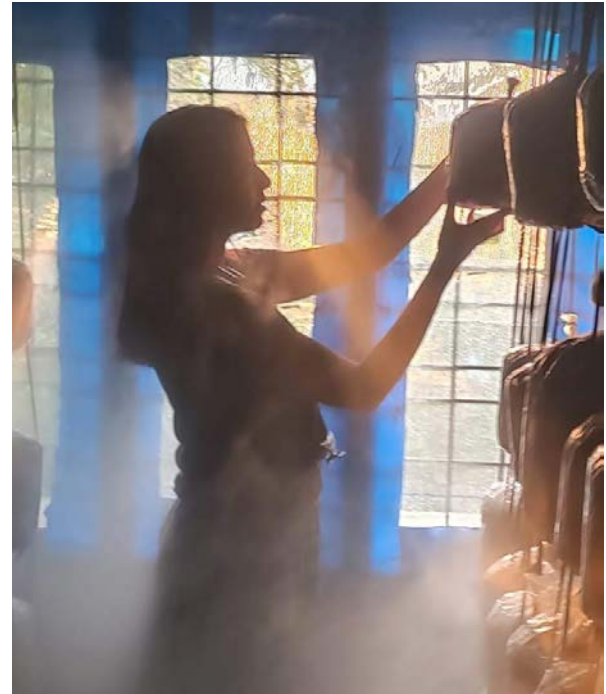
Ankitha's business model is unique, as they offer a guaranteed yield while also providing an entrepreneurial opportunity. They ensure that the mushrooms are of high quality and sold at a fair price. Additionally, they provide relevant machinery like the Mist System, designed by Ankitha, which is essential for mushroom growth. Through her initiative, Mushroom Empowerment, Ankitha is not only helping farmers and Self Help Groups (SHGs) generate income but also creating a positive impact on the environment and community.

Currently, Ankitha and her team are working on creating a fully automated, integrated mushroom grow unit which guarantees a 100% yield; without the need for complicated science behind cultivation or human intervention.



Under the guidance of the Indian Institute of Horticulture Research (IIHR), and the Association of Lady Entrepreneurs (ALEAP), they plan to introduce this technology in their state with government funding.

Ankitha credits the Women's Startup Program (WSP) for coming at the right time in her entrepreneurial journey. As a founder, she finds it incredibly rewarding to see the positive impact that Mushroom Empowerment has had on the lives of farmers and women Self Help Groups. Their initiative is helping these groups gain financial independence, provide for their families, improve their overall quality of life, and promote the consumption of healthy mushrooms in the market.





Supriya Kulkarni

Vivid Puzzles

Inspired by the famous Thomas Edison quote 'To invent, you need a good imagination and a pile of junk', Supriya Kulkarni Deshpande is on a quest to spark creativity amongst children through her startup; Vivid Puzzles.



Being a school teacher and a parent, Mrs Supriya Kulkarni Deshpande observed that jigsaw puzzles are one of the most powerful learning tools for developing visual discrimination and spatial skills in children. While exploring puzzle options for her 5-year-old daughter, Supriya could only find limited scope of subjects with repetitive artwork. Just as she was looking at DIY wooden block puzzle patterns, the opportunity-of-a-lifetime knocked at her door in the form of Women Startup Program (WSP) 3.0 by IIM Visakhapatnam.

During the program, she connected with jigsaw-loving children and parents to understand the scope of the business. After receiving validation, she started Vivid Puzzles; a startup born to design creative and eco-friendly puzzles for children.

As an entrepreneur, the first hurdle for Supriya was to understand the processes to manufacture the puzzles and to find manufacturers for jigsaw puzzle products with Minimum Order Quantity (MOQ). Her WSP peers and mentors guided her through each milestone in her startup journey.

With a presence in marketplaces, the products by Vivid Puzzles have been receiving a positive feedback. Taking it as a sign, Supriya wishes to work on a variety of jigsaw puzzle designs for children and adults, which offer a quality learning and family time.



Dr Aparna Ayyagari

Vidh-Ya

Behind every great leader is an indispensable circle of trusted mentors. As the youngsters of this generation are our future, Dr Ayyagari's, Vidh-Ya, aims to tackle the confidence and opportunity gap for adolescents across the globe.



Having been a self-motivated student, Aparna's parents never questioned, or stopped her from, whatever she wanted to do. She is a triple postgraduate and a UGC Fellow. Aparna then joined the Government of India, as a junior scientist working on sequencing the human DNA.

Aparna had an eye for detail and by the time her first born child was five years old, she realized that there were certain aspects in him which could be explored and nurtured. She worked with him to make him better; keeping the goal was that each day he should be better than the previous one.

And that was the basis of her start-up, which she put into action much later. Her second son, a tennis prodigy, was the youngest player ever qualified for the Under-14 category. He also heads an NGO and is contributing back to society. Her daughter, stands at World Number 1 for her category in chess and was recently awarded the Pradhan Mantri Rashtriya Bal Puraskar; the highest national civilian award for children.

Aparna believes that every human being has great potential. All that is needed is the right mentoring. And that is what her venture is all about, mentoring and guiding adolescents. Helping them recognise their inherent talents and realise their full potential. Three years since she started, Aparna now interacts with, and helps, children from all over India, the Middle East, and Singapore. And, she attributes the successful launch of her enterprise to the Woman Startup Program (WSP) of IIMV FIELD and NSRCEL.



Aayushi Jauhari

Kayantar Foundation

Aayushi Jauhari believes helping people has to be in the fabric of your DNA. Through Kayantar Foundation, she co-created a network of committed development professionals to support communities acquire conducive living conditions.



When a child drops out of school, it may not necessarily be due to an issue with the child's education, but rather due to their parents' migration, unemployment, or health problems. Aayushi Jauhari used to organise theatre and street plays on social issues since her college days. Continuing her passions while working in TCS, her street plays evolved into volunteering in the neighboring villages and enacting plays with messages to spread awareness on community issues like dowry, gender inequality, atrocities against women, and patriarchy. This was when she truly got into working for the betterment of victims of societal norms.

When stationed in Indore, she started her own volunteering organization and experienced first-hand, the highs and lows of running a volunteering group. She did a Post-graduate Diploma in Developmental Leadership from ISJM. That's when she realised that there is an education sector, a livelihood sector, the health sector, governance, social entrepreneurship, and more.

Facing numerous issues and organizations across various sectors, each with their own approach, Aayushi advocated for a multi-pronged approach to achieve better and more comprehensive results. And one of the biggest hurdles that she had to overcome in the initial stages of her start-up was convincing people that the concept of a multi-problem approach can exist and be successful.

According to Aayushi, IIMV FIELD is the foundation stone for the Kayantar Foundation, as the incubation centre helped her develop a clear understanding of her goals and the impact she intends to make in society.



Alisha Garnaik

The Period Pratha

‘That time of the month’ often has a negative connotation. Giving a positive spin to it, Alisha Garnaik’s The Period Pratha is addressing the stigma surrounding menstruation with its line of period care and grooming products.

the ~~period~~ प्रथा

After witnessing the poor menstrual hygiene conditions of women and girls in remote villages, Alisha Garnaik realized the need for menstrual hygiene awareness and breaking the associated stigma.

Alisha Garnaik worked for a media consultancy firm while on her semester break. She was tasked with a CSR initiative of visiting villages, in the vicinity of Vedanta Alumina, to find out their grievances regarding the Vedanta Plant. Armed with a questionnaire, she would interact with people in groups, and individually, in remote areas like Kalahandi. It was there that she came across the primitive conditions that women were subjected to during their menstruation.

Women during their period were forced to reside in a separate shack under unquestionable hygienic conditions. Born and brought up in Rourkela, Alisha completed her Bachelors in English Honours, with Mass Communication, at MATS University, Chhattisgarh. She was a 19-year old on a mission. Her target audience were the underprivileged in government schools and that was the beginning of Period Pratha, starting as a social awareness campaign. After the COVID-19 outbreak, Alisha decided to move from an awareness campaign to creating, and promoting, a product that could help them during their menstruation. She approached many organisations – local and international, did a lot of research, and eventually came up with a prototype. In order to create a feasible business plan, she also contacted the incubation centres - IIMV FIELD and NSRCEL - and benefitted from their mentorship. Alisha felt the sessions were very holistic and engaging.



Dissy George

Back to Nature

Dissy George, the founder of Back to Nature, has always been passionate about eco-friendly solutions. Her journey began with a thoughtful effort to supply biodegradable and eco-friendly coir fiber pots, which eventually took shape into a venture.

With the support of partners like Glowar Organics & Innovations Pvt. Ltd., The Social Forestry Division, Indira Gandhi Zoological Park (Visakhapatnam), Khadiyam Nurseries, and Kerala Kala Samithi, Back to Nature has grown into a successful company that is providing development of domestic & export markets, skill-building, and women's empowerment.

Dissy's commitment to creating sustainable solutions is evident in the company's focus on designing vertical, and tabletop, gardens with lightweight coir pots. She is dedicated to making it easy for people to start kitchen gardens in concrete spaces, and her efforts have brought awareness to the benefits of organic kitchen gardening. With her marketing and outreach efforts, Dissy has been able to empower women and create a positive change in society.



Pooja Agarwal

Flow Experiences

Pooja Agarwal, founder of 'Flow Experiences', is a seasoned entrepreneur with a passion for bringing people together. Her startup is a one-stop-destination for immersive recreation programmes, centred around over 160 unique and diverse arts.

Pooja's entrepreneurial journey began with a deep understanding of the importance of employee wellbeing. She had worked with several startups where she saw firsthand the negative effects of employee burnout and disengagement. Determined to make a difference, Pooja founded Flow Experiences with the goal of creating a more immersive and engaging way for companies to enhance the happiness and comfort of their employees.

The programmes at Flow Experiences are designed to boost employee wellbeing, relieve stress, and foster relationship building. By streamlining the coordination process with artists and vendors, the organisation makes it easy for companies to organise recreational activities for their employees.



Chabi Agarwal
Learning Buffet

Chabi Agarwal's love for design and passion for education came together when she discovered the challenges faced by caregivers of children with learning disabilities. As a graphic designer, she was acutely aware of how the lack of access to the right tools and resources could hinder the education and growth of these children. Determined to help bridge this gap, she founded Learning Buffet; an Ed-Tech startup that provides a one-stop solution for caregivers of children with learning disabilities.

Chabi's vision for Learning Buffet is to create an e-commerce platform that offers personalized tools and resources for children with diverse learning needs. She believes that human-centered design techniques are essential to achieving this goal. By working closely with caregivers and educators, Chabi is able to design, curate, and modify the platform to meet the unique needs of each child. Her aim is to create an environment where children can learn and grow at their own pace, free from the limitations imposed by traditional educational methods.



Bhavana Kondeti
TraditionOnWay

Bhavana Kondeti, the founder of 'TraditionOnWay', is on a mission to promote the rich traditions of India through her innovative startup.

Bhavana's journey with 'TraditionOnWay' began with a simple idea of helping lower-middle-class, and middle-class, people who cannot afford a qualified fashion designer. She wanted to connect students pursuing fashion designing with these individuals through her website, providing them with affordable options to look special on their special occasions. Her initiative not only supports traditional artisans but also helps aspiring fashion designers gain exposure and experience.

'TraditionOnWay' is not just a business for Bhavana; it's a passion project that aims to make a difference in people's lives. She believes that by promoting Indian traditions, she can create a better future for everyone involved in the process. Bhavana's vision for 'TraditionOnWay' is to become a one-stop-shop for all things traditional in India, and with her dedication and hard work, she's well on her way to achieving it.



Sireesha M
KisanLinks India

Sireesha M's journey towards founding KisanLinks India was shaped by her commitment to the agri-industry and the challenges faced by farmers in India. Her experience of growing up in a farming family instilled in her a keen sense of the struggles and hardships that farmers face on a daily basis.

After completing her MBA in Agri-Marketing, Sireesha worked tirelessly in the agri-industry, providing support and services to farmers in rural areas. Her work allowed her to witness firsthand the difficulties faced by farmers, including a lack of knowledge, resources, and market opportunities. Determined to make a difference, Sireesha decided to take the plunge and co-founded KisanLinks India.

At KisanLinks India, Sireesha's goal is to create a one-stop solution for all the needs of farmers, whether it is related to agri storage, market access, or knowledge sharing. Her vision is to provide a 24x7 customer support service that is language specific and highly responsive to the needs of farmers. With this support, farmers will be able to access storage facilities, market opportunities, and resources, which will enable them to achieve greater success in their businesses.



Srividya Pinapala
Midore

Srividya Pinapala's Midore is a social initiative that aims to bring farmers and agricultural enthusiasts closer on digital platforms where they can exchange information about sustainable farming practices.

The project, according to her, is centred around creating awareness about green and natural spaces and making data available at one place as an aggregator. She envisions Midore expanding into different verticals in the green and natural space to digitally educate more people with minimal cost. Srividya's entrepreneurial journey started when she saw the challenges faced by her family's farming community in India. They had limited access to online resources, and there was a lack of sustainable practices, making it difficult for them to make ends meet. She created Midore to address these challenges and connect farmers with digital platforms to exchange information on sustainable practices.

For Srividya, Midore is not just about farming; it's about creating a sustainable future for everyone. She is optimistic that Midore can spread more awareness to every corner of the country and digitally educate more women, men, and youth with minimal cost.



IIMV FIELD

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